

KEGEL EXERCISE

Ashwani Mudra

Vaishali Narkar and Sanjeev Khandekar

2007

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Lacerations on the Cheek of Time

Gitanjali Dang

Patches of perspiration appear on their locally manufactured formal attire. Numbers flicker superciliously on screens towering overhead. They engulf and transfix the habitues of this vast room, where everything gravitates towards the trading floor. The ticker conveys its Attention Deficit Disorder with hubris. Detailing fickle market rituals, it evangelises the imminent financialisation of the world.

The traders are venting their spleens. The open outcry has quickly mutated into an eddy crescendo that captivates and repulses in equal measure. The frenzied scene calls to mind the dubious proceedings of a séance. However, it is not just a mere rush of blood to the head that propels this consumptive madness...

The life expectancy index indicates that the threshold of mortality has receded among most nationalities. In India, at the commencement of the current millennium, life expectancy achieved a new high of 64 years. Subsequently, the age – mental, not chronological – at which adolescence receives a kick in its shins, leaps out of its shoes and finally allows adulthood to settle in, has also been nudged further away.

It is my suggestion that we treat these polyester-clad spleen venters as a hybrid genus. In them, we find that the idealism of youth has dissipated and the follies of recklessness and petulance have escalated. These adults have wilfully aborted the wondrousness of adolescence and in the vacuum they have allowed cruelty to ossify.

In his exhibition, *The Kegel Exercises: Aswani Mudra*, comprising sculptural installations and a video, Sanjeev Khandekar invokes the phenomenon of late multicultural capitalism, helmed by a new breed of adults who retain the cruellest features of adolescence. For the exhibition, the artist treats the ubiquitous ticker as a carbuncle that prefigures perils simmering under its taut surface.

This, however, is not the first time Khandekar has occasioned an inquiry into the quicksilver ticker's machinations. The ticker first appeared in his exhibition *All that I wanna do* (2005) in an 84-foot-long incarnation titled *Money ain't shit to me*. It occupied one entire wall and its distorted reflection, as seen in acrylic mirrors, the other.

In his sculptural installations, Khandekar manipulates the iconography, the typeface and the palette of the electronic concatenation to create abstractions. To achieve this end, the artist studied the ticker at length. This was followed by a software intervention that occasioned the recreation and the warping of the ticker in a desired resolution. Although there are two conceivable readings of the abstractions, this was dwell on them a little later.

In *The Kegel Exercises: Aswani Mudra* Khandekar retains the intercessional character of his paintings. The artist is part of the system but he takes pride in being a systemic anomaly, flagging blind spots as dissent.

In addition to its oppositional character, Khandekar's body of work has perpetually been grounded in biological certainties. First, he adopts this applecart of certainties; then he proceeds to disturb it with a metaphysical apple. Questions of metaphysics are ultimately ineluctable but with investment patterns controlling life cycles, metaphysical concerns are perceived as being frumpy.

Khandekar describes the current situation as 'a party on the Titanic'. And a party it is, where the light skidding off the disco mirror balls is dazzling us blind: rendering incoherent all that lies beyond the purview of our global consumerist milieu.

The artist is no incorrigible leftist, intent on carrying out a hatchet job. He is disconcerted by the currents of new fascism that are pillaging all social systems, which do not give their nod to profitmaking as an acceptable yardstick. Khandekar is in favour of resolutions because he is fully aware that sooner, rather than later, the sinking ship will force the party to disband.

Marble madness

In 1982, when the 22-year-old Khandekar migrated to Bombay from Sangli district, he encountered the stultifying assault of the city's constantly changing sensibilities. Around this time advertisements started marauding newsprint. The dailies were rife with assurances of apartments with marble flooring. These adverts transformed marble slabs into bounce boards that emitted a marmoreal aura, which lit up the melodramatic sets of shallow bourgeois episodes.

Real estate companies still hard-sell marble and its lustrous permutations, but a line extracted from Yukio Mishima's *The Sailor Who Fell from Grace with The Sea* tips the scale against builders. We feel a sudden onrush of perspective when Mishima writes simply, yet disdainfully, "Then the light in the vestibule clicked on and the imported marble floor floated into view."

Over the centuries, marble has borne the freight of its privileged position. In Andrzej Wajda's *Man of Marble* (1976), a critique of the grand narrative of the communist regime, we witness the subterfuges of socialist realism.

In the film, myopic social realism recognises the realisation of a marble public statue of Mateusz Birkut, a Polish bricklayer. In doing so, the administration tries to graft marble's perceived aura to the ordinary, craftily translating it into a heroic ideal. The film concludes in Gdańsk (Danzig), a remarkably prescient move on Wajda's part. It was here in 1976 that the Solidarity movement effectuated the devolution of communism.

From being an object of desire to being an object at the receiving end of much derision, marble has been visited upon by the entire gamut of sentiments. Earlier this year, on July 7, when celebration galore marked the Taj Mahal's unhindered entry into the final list of the New Seven Wonders of the World, one was reminded of poet and lyricist Abdul Haie Sahir Ludhianvi (1922-1980).

In 1943, Ludhianvi published a volume of his Urdu poems entitled *Talkhian*. At a time when hell and all its neighbouring constituencies were breaking loose and singing paeans to the Taj Mahal, Ludhianvi, a communist, reproached the edifice that Rabindranath Tagore had earlier cited as "a teardrop on the cheek of time".

In the poem Taj Mahal, Ludhianvi insists his lover step away from the normative moon 'n' marble illuminated skies that hover over the Taj and meet him someplace else because the Taj mocks the lives and loves of the common man by deeming them commonplace. He concludes the poem thus:

*An ganit logon ne duniya mein mohabbat ki hai,
Kaun kahta hai ke saadiq na the jazbe unke?
Lekin un ke lieye tashhir ka samaan hi nahin
Kyonke who log bhi apni hi tarah muflis the.*

Countless men in this world have loved and gone,
Who would say their loves weren't truthful or strong?
But in the name of their loves no memorial is raised,
For they, too, like you and me belonged to the common throng.

When Khandekar cuts abstractions into marble for The Kegel Exercises, a suite of four marble installations, he claims lineage to a cast of dissenters comprising the likes of Wajda, Mishima and Ludhianvi. By forging an alliance between a material that is smugly aware of the polarisations triggered by hierarchies, and the ticker, an electronic missive that delivers words of absolute financialisation, Khandekar does not seek to embolden either. Instead he harnesses both, in conjunction with the contractions and expansions engendered by the Kegel Exercises, to create abstractions and/or distortions that spawn the dramas of trading and sexuality.

It has become increasingly commonplace to regurgitate throwaway lines that liken sex with every conceivable verb, noun and adjective. It would interest the reader to note that the analogy is not merely an attention-grabbing antic on the part of the artist. The broad rubric,

under which the four installations are introduced, is derived from an exercise routine named after and advocated by Dr. Arnold Kegel. The exercises are designed to tauten pelvic muscles, collectively known as Kegel muscles, and are aimed at tipping sexual gratification.

In the four sculptural installations *Ischiocavernosus Muscle*, *Saliva With a Portion of Tongue Enlarged*, *Levator Ani Muscle* and *Micrograph of Rat Fucking Rat* - three of which are titled after muscles in the pelvic area - *pietre dure* work has been employed to realise paintings in stone. Khandekar manipulates a variety of marbles - Makrana, Wonder and Black Indian - to serve his own needs. He plies four humongous slabs of marble and partially divests them of their colour habits and peculiar textures to create a base for the inlay work.

Moss agate, moonstone, lapis lazuli, onyx and badal comprise the roster of semi-precious stones that help ossify the ticker in marble. In these installations the ticker, ordinarily a guidepost for market vicissitudes, transmutes into a work where rabid financialisation and sexuality intermingle and develop into a combustive current of suppressed desire.

When Khandekar superimposes the clenching and unclenching of the Kegel muscles onto the stock market ticker, he immediately unsheathes the edge of desire and its centrality to the businesses of today. This conflation of the muscles and the ticker is not merely metaphorical as the artist incorporates micrographs depicting the reproductive organs and the act of intercourse.

Khandekar's work has variously pivoted on the Freudian principle of suppressed desire. The Kegel exercises become symptomatic of this latent desire. In the artist's work, the libido once operationalised, rapidly devolves into the destrudo. Sexuality as manifested in the exercises represents an unequivocal desire to keep the huge machine of trade and finance firing. In doing so Khandekar likens biological ferment caused by trading fluctuations to acts of foreplay and coitus. He reckons that we have integrated trading into the intimate idiom of everyday life.

The syntax of the ticker, impelled by its compulsive character, rises, dips, grows, shrinks, enunciates, grovels... In *The Kegel Exercises*, Khandekar establishes that this multiplicity and relentless bustle is heralded by actions that occur on the pelvic floor. The shenanigans of the trading floor are subsequent to those of the pulsing muscles of the pelvic floor.

Incidentally, *Marble Madness* is one of the earliest arcade games: in it you control a marble and race against time or an opponent to reach the goal line.

Flushed away

Over the past few years, Khandekar has displayed a protean artistic language. He has investigated at length the formal values of painting, sculpture, installation and drawing, not necessarily in that order. With Encore, he adds video to his repertoire. In addition to the video, Encore constitutes a marble commode and a washbowl.

Recently archaeologists working in Rome discovered a 2nd century bath complex believed to be part of a vast, luxurious residence of a billionaire who gathered his fellow Romans there to unwind. Among other things, the two-storey complex includes embellished hot rooms and most importantly, marble latrines. With this sculptural installation, the artist elbows our continuing and uncouth fascination with marble.

In the sculptural installation, the white Makrana marble commode and washbowl are inlaid with sweet water pearls, jade, moss agate, jasper, ruby and American diamonds. Makrana, incidentally, was the indigenous marble variety favoured by Shah Jahan when he commissioned the facade of the Taj Mahal.

In the video, the viewers are confronted with the abuses of a gelding and a mare. Khandekar could have played smart and employed a bull in the video and thereby dart-boarded the stock market without much prevarication. By choosing the gelding and the mare over the bull, he affords the works a sense of closure. In that, although Dr. Kegel contemporised and popularised the Kegel callisthenics for a stunningly bored generation that was forever looking to vacation with the unfamiliar, the exercises have quietly been in circulation in India for centuries. Hatha Yogis inaugurated the Aswani Mudra (Horse Gesture) in the 15th century and have since been practicing and teaching it.

Of late one has rarely, if ever, wandered into a work of art that is repulsive and open to the possibilities of getting booed and hissed at by the mandarins that be. The video is repulsive, which is always a sturdy attribute for art to possess. This aberrant character is the link language it shares with Matthew Barney's oeuvre. In Barney's works, the viewers stand by as mesmerizingly outlandish rituals - women urinating on stage, flensing of whales and insertion of ice screws into the artist's arse - are played out.

In Khandekar's video, the contractions and dilations of the animals' rectums iterates without any dillydallying what the sculptural installations in The Kegel Exercises have already asserted. Financialisation is synonymous with bestialisation, which in turn is occasioned by the churlish destrudo.

Khandekar's *Encore* is not phrased in a *sotto voce*. The video plays to the accompaniment of the sound of a flush being pulled. The gushing and the gurgling of the flush doubles up as the voice of unreason.

The gaping orifice is common to both the sculptural installation and the video. In the video, the convulsive anus morphs into a rictus of pain and desire. In the sculptural installation, the orifice essays the part of a town crier and announces that everything is getting washed down the drain.

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Diploma in Indian Aesthetics (Mumbai University). Her areas of interest include the Internet and the World Wide Web and how

the two have impacted contemporary Indian art and artworks.

Notes

1. Yukio Mishima, *The Sailor Who Fell From Grace With The Sea*, translated from the Japanese by John Nathan

(Vintage Books, 1994)

2. Abdul Haie Sahir Ludhianvi, 'Taj Mahal' in *Masterpieces of Urdu Nazm* translated from the Urdu by K C Kanda

(Sterling Publications, 2000)



Title: Levator Ani Muscle

Medium: Makrana marble, Lapis Lazuli, Onyx and coloured marble dust

Size : 6'x 4'

Year: 2007